

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*When Things Fall Apart ~ Heart Advice for Difficult Times
Going Against the Grain ~ How to...be centered*

August 10th, 2025



"Ground Swell" by Edward Hooper, 1939

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on SLANE and BROTHER JAMES' AIR
Prélude, Fugue et Variation (César Franck)
Trio in G-moll (Joseph Rheinberger) and Improvisation
Gymnopedie No. 1 (Erik Satie)
Prelude in G Major, BWV 541 / 1 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz & Sarah Fuhrmeister

No one knows the name of this day;
born quietly from the deepest night,
its face is hidden in the light,
demanding nothing for itself,
opening out to offer each of us
a field of brightness that travels ahead,
providing in time, ground to hold our footsteps
and the light of thought to show the way.

The mind of the day draws no attention;
it dwells within the silence of elegance
to create a space for all our words,
drawing us to listen inward and outward.

We seldom notice how each day is a holy place
where the eucharist of the ordinary happens,
transforming our broken fragments
into an eternal continuity that keeps us.

Somewhere in us a dignity presides
that is more gracious than the smallness
that fuels us with fear and force,
a dignity that trusts the form a day takes.

*At the beginning of this day,
we give thanks, Holy One,
for being betrothed to the unknown
and for the secret work
through which the mind of the day
and wisdom of the soul becomes one.*

[adapted / o'donohue]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering** *The Sun is on the Sea and Shore*
The sun is on the sea and shore, a new day has begun
With morning hymns we will adore the blessed Three-in-One;
And we shall praise you ever more, until the day is done.

BROTHER JAMES' AIR

Your love is ever in our view, like shining stars by night
Your gifts are every morning new, Oh God of love and light;
Your mercy, like the heaven's blue, fills our dazzled sight.

We do not know what grief and care each coming day may bring;
The heart shall find some gladness there that trusts you in each thing;
The life that serves you everywhere will never cease to sing.

***Prayer of Awareness**
Gracious and Holy One,
we gather this morning opening to your healing power.
We do not understand all the things that make us whole,
nor the mystery of all that hurts us in body, mind, and spirit.

Rev. Fregin

But we do know this:
that the presence of the Christ,
the hidden wholeness coursing through your wondrous universe,
weaves, from the dropped threads of unfinished lives,
a fabric of unmatched beauty.

We come this morning, O God,
seeking less to understand this Healing Source
than to open ourselves to its sacred flow,
released in us through this simple act of gathering -
singing, praying, and holding one another
and our beautiful, but often broken world -
in your love. [adapt/bsanguin]

*This we pray.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit** "God Is Our Refuge"
Cathedral Choir

W.A. MOZART

***The Lord's Prayer**
*Eternal Spirit,
Earth-maker, Pain-bearer, Life-giver,
Source of all that is and that shall be.
Father and Mother of us all,
Loving God, in whom is heaven:*

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

*The hallowing of your name echo through the universe!
The way of your justice be followed
By all peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done
By all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom
Sustain our hope and come on earth.*

*With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure and
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.*

*For you reign in the glory of power that is love and grace,
now and forever. Amen and Amen!* -New Zealand Book of Prayer

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

In peace, God has prepared
a path for us this day.
*Help us to walk in peace
this day, O God.*

When we listen,
let us listen for peace
with our whole heart.
When we speak,
let us speak words of peace
that heal, rather than harm.

*May our path this day
lead to peace -
for those we love,
and for the world.*

This morning may the Heart of Peace be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Gospel of Mark, chapter four

Sarah Fuhrmeister

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

This is the Gospel of Grace and Justice..
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

We give you thanks, wondrous God,
for the mystery of creation, for the miracle of life,
and for seeds of renewal you plant deep within all living things.
We are grateful that you continue to create and recreate forever,
mending what is broken, and making all things new.

Holy God of mystery, love, and power,
we give thanks for One who came among us
to teach us the way of restoration,
healing the sick and feeding the hungry,
offering all people a destiny of purpose and meaning.

Remembering Jesus, we offer thanks
for in joy and suffering,
sickness and health,
in life and in death,
we are never alone.

By your Spirit give us a renewed life
so that we who have known your healing touch,
may share your love with those in need of your goodness and grace.

May it always be so.
Amen and Amen.

[adapt/rduck&pwilson-kastner]

Meditation Anthem

“Why Do I Use My Paper, Ink, and Pen?”
Laude

WILLIAM BYRD

Message

Going Against the Grain

Rev. Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin, Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz & Sarah Fuhrmeister

In these moments,
for all that is chaotic
within us...
let there come silence.

Let there be
a calming
of the clamoring,
a stilling

of the voices that
have laid their claim
on us,
that have made their
home in us,

that go with us
even to the
holy places
but will not let us rest,
will not let us hear
our lives
with wholeness
or feel the grace
that fashioned us.

[adapt/jrichardson]

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Fregin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Hope"
Cathedral Choir

YSAYE BARNWELL

*"If we want hope to survive in this world today, then every day we've got
to pray on, walk on, work on, march on, teach on, sing on."*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

Holy One, we give thanks
for the truth that has been inscribed into our hearts
and into the heart of every human being,
there to be read and revered.

We give thanks that there are ways of seeing and sensitives of knowing
hidden deep in the sacredness of our souls,
waiting to be discovered,
ready to be set free.

As we bring our gifts and ourselves to you this day,
open our senses to wisdom's inner promptings
that we may give voice to what we hear in our souls
and be changed for the healing of the world.

*And then, O God, in the days to come,
may we listen for truth in every living soul
and together, may we be changed for the well-being of the world.*

- J. Phillip Newell, Prayer for Wisdom

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

As we leave this sacred place
remind us, O God, who we are.

Enliven our spirits
and let us be so close to you...
that as we wake
we will listen.

*That as we rise
we will listen.*

That before our first words
of the day
we will listen.

*That when we meet
we will listen.*

That at noontime
we will listen.

*That at dusk
we will listen.*

That at the gathering
of night
we will listen.

*That entering sleep
we will listen.*

[adpt/janrichardson]

Each day, O God,
may we listen
and then, speak of
your love.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

“Grateful To Be”
Cathedral Choir

arr. DAVID HARRIS

*Hymn for the Journey

Come Now, O Wisdom

SLANE

Come now, O Wisdom, we need your clear voice;
Speak and awaken our hearts to rejoice.
Gracious Creator of more than we know,
In your own image may we ever grow.

Come now, O Wisdom, abide in our souls;
Stir in us visions of life free and whole.
Wisdom, our pathway to justice and peace,
With you our dreams find their fullest release.

Wisdom, more precious than rubies or gold;
With you our graces forever unfold.
No fame or fortune with you can compare;
Pour out your blessings, so rich and so rare.

Wisdom your grace joins all heaven and earth;
With you we labor new life to give birth.
Come now, O Wisdom, our Midwife and Friend,
Open our hearts to your world without end.

-lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Davy Jones plays his Organ (Hans Zimmer, adapted for Organ by C. Bull)

Inside The Music

“In the late 16th Century, William Byrd held a unique position in England. He was in the Queen’s favor, and under her protection. He was widely revered as one of the living master composers of his age. Yet, he was also a known Catholic at a time when Catholicism was illegal and punishable by death. Breathe that in. It’s hard to imagine such a reality. It’s also easy to transfer the crushing weight of state sponsored injustice onto a great many circumstances today. What made Byrd extra special was that he spoke out against the injustice. He used his position of favor to make what case he could for changing the laws. The Queen listened, and slowly brought an end to what is known as recusancy laws. Her final triumph was ensuring that her nephew James, born a Catholic, followed her on the throne to put a final end to it. One of Byrd’s most notable justice actions was the writing of “Why Do I Use My Paper, Ink, and Pen?”. The text was written by a fellow Catholic and recusant. To use any of his writings would have sentenced anyone else to death. Byrd didn’t care. He had just heard that several of his colleagues

had been executed by the state for simply identifying as Catholic. He didn't have an answer to such grave injustice, so he created art. The piece itself has no answers. It asks the questions we're all asking regarding what difference we can make against such injustice. It says that surely heavenly voices were more suited to sing the souls of those lost into their rest. And it notes the futility of celebrating those who suffer at the hands of an unjust cause. Ultimately it leaves us with more questions. Emotionally, though, it serves as a catharsis, bringing together those who feel tied down by injustice. We are encouraged to act in some way, even if small, even if simply joining in song. Byrd was arrested for writing this song, if you can believe that. The Queen learned of his detention, and had him released before he could be tried. He remained in his high position as the head musician of England. It's hard to say how much his influence mattered to her, but her actions made it seem as if he mattered in the dynamic ways that only an artist can matter to a person of the state. He could have bowed to the pressure of the time, but instead, he used his influence to make the changes he could. Mozart wrote this week's introit when he was on a visit to London at the age of 9 in 1765. The fact that he wrote it in English reflects his location of writing, and makes it unique among his other music. His choice to set Psalm 46 also stands out. Some people think that Shakespeare had an outsized role in the creation of the King James Bible. Psalm 46, according to them, holds the key. Shakespeare was 46 the year the KJV was published. Psalm 46 sits in the middle of that Bible. At 46 words from the start of the Psalm we find the word "shake" and 46 words from the end of it we find "spear." I don't know how long this idea has circulated, but the fact that Mozart set this text, which holds a sentiment outside of the bulk of his religious music, and set it in English, tells me there is a likelihood that he knew about it. Today, I'm choosing to believe that he did, because it aligns with our theme. Stepping outside of the normal systems that govern us takes being curious, hearing the world from different angles, and opening ourselves to wonder. Perhaps Shakespeare did plant a simple act of creative defiance in the middle of the first mass-produced religious text. Maybe he did it to remind those who found his puzzle that we all have a role to play, even if in small ways. The Psalmist reminds us that there are answers to the problems that plague us. When we seek with love, even wars have solutions. At the end of the day, those solutions rely on our involvement. We don't have to individually carry the entire burden. That tends to be a recipe for disaster. We are called to stay in the mix, to be active in centering, moving toward established goals, teaching others to come alongside us, and singing together to share a common energy." – Dr. David Harris